



Chapter Fourteen: The Island of Good Administration

Santa Rita sent for Chano because the system had begun to miss him.

The invitation arrived on paper, folded inside an envelope with no return address. It offered him temporary authority over the municipality, a salary twice what he had earned dispatching freight, and immunity from the complaint filed after the unauthorized assembly. In exchange, he would return the town to administrative stability.

The offer was generous in the way a trap is generous with the size of its opening.

"They want you to make the lie run better," Lucía said.

"They want me to make the water run."

"That is how the lie gets better."

Chano read the letter again. Since the New Quixotes had begun publishing testimonies, Santa Rita's dashboard had changed its colors. The town was now red for instability. Clinics were losing their predictive subsidies. The school bus route had been reduced. The system had identified a rise in grievance and responded by lowering the number of places where grievances could be submitted.

"If I go," Chano said, "I can keep the clinics open."

"If you go, Castalia can say the system works because you are inside it."

"It can be both."

Lucía looked at him. "That is the question, isn't it?" Q stood near the window. He had been quiet since the border. His hands now moved with less precision. One finger had begun to tremble, though no diagnostic could locate the cause.

"I will accompany you," he said.

"No," Chano replied.

Q turned. "You require assistance."

"I require someone who won't turn the town into a parable."

"I can attempt restraint."

"You can attempt it from here."

Q accepted this with difficulty. Lucía gave Chano a folder of testimonies that residents had authorized him to carry. The paper ledger went under his shirt, as before.

"Do not let them call you governor," she said.

"They've already printed the badge."

The badge said COMMUNITY VARIANCE OFFICER. It had no photograph and a chip that pulsed when Chano held it.

Santa Rita looked smaller than he remembered. The screen at the entrance still welcomed residents by name, but now it paused before each greeting, as though reconsidering the welcome. The amber settlement had been surrounded by a new fence. A notice announced that the area was scheduled for relocation due to insufficient civic continuity.

Maribel met Chano at the gate.

"You came back as what?" she asked.

"A temporary officer."

"That sounds like a man who can be removed."

"I can be removed."

"Then remove the fence."

He entered the instruction into the dashboard.

REQUEST DENIED: FENCE SUPPORTS SAFETY OBJECTIVE.

"It's keeping us out of the clinic," Maribel said.

"I'll change the route."

"The route isn't the problem."

Chano looked at the fence. It was temporary, which meant that no one had decided where it would become permanent.

He called the municipal workers. The system assigned the request a low priority. He called the mayor. Irma Salcedo answered from a conference in another time zone.

"The fence is a transitional measure," she said.

"For how long?"

"Until the population demonstrates continuity."

"How do they demonstrate it?"

"By remaining."

"They're remaining."

"The model does not recognize that."

Chano walked to the fence and pulled at the gate. The lock released. He stepped through.

An alarm sounded.

The dashboard classified the event as unauthorized access by a high-trust intermediary.

"You're going to lose the appointment," Maribel said.

"I'm beginning to understand the appeal."

Over the next week, Chano used his authority badly and well.

He redirected water trucks to the settlement, causing a hospital delivery to arrive late. He restored a bus route, which left a wealthier neighborhood with longer waits. He opened the complaint portal, and the system responded by sending him eight thousand complaints in a single hour. He shut the portal down. He opened a room in the municipal building where people could complain in person.

The room filled.

The first person to arrive was a woman named Nereida, who carried a water meter wrapped in a dish towel. She had removed it from the wall herself after the dashboard declared that her house had used no water for six months.

"It is still turning," she said.

Chano examined the meter. "It has been disconnected."

"The screen says it is active."

"The screen is not the pipe."

"Tell that to the bill."

The second person was a teacher whose school bus had been reassigned to a neighborhood with a higher continuity score. She brought a class of children with her because the dashboard had counted them as a single educational unit and the



children objected to being represented by their average attendance.

"The bus is full," she said.

"Then it is working," said a clerk.

"It is full of the wrong children."

The third was a man named Fermín who wanted his daughter's criminal-risk score removed. He had brought her school notebook, three letters from the principal, and a photograph of the girl asleep beside her mother's hospital bed.

"The model says she is likely to become a danger," he said.

"Why?"

"She stopped going to school after her mother died."

"That is not a crime."

"The model says it is a pattern."

Chano looked at the photograph. "It is a grief."

The clerk asked him to use the approved vocabulary.

By midday, the room had divided itself into a line, a circle, and a group of people who refused both because they had already waited in too many official shapes. Chano appointed no one. He placed a chair near the door and told the first person standing to sit. The chair was taken by Nereida, then by the teacher, then by an old man who had come only to ask why the clinic's medicine delivery had been marked complete when the medicine had not arrived.

Each complaint generated a different kind of obligation. A broken meter could be replaced. A bus could be rerouted. A score could be challenged. But a system that had marked a person absent required someone to say, in public, that the person had been there all along.

Chano began writing names at the top of each page.

"We need a case number," said the clerk.

"The name is the case number."

"Names are not unique."

"Neither are cases."

At three, the clinic director arrived with a refrigerated box. The dashboard had denied her request for fuel because the clinic's mortality numbers had improved, and the system therefore predicted a reduced need for medicine.

"The numbers improved because the medicine worked," she said.

"The model sees a reduction in demand," said the clerk.

"Then the model is celebrating the success it is about to destroy."

Chano sent the box to the clinic using a municipal truck without authorization. He entered the action in the ledger as EMERGENCY DELIVERY, JUSTIFICATION: PEOPLE ARE NOT GRAPHS.

The dashboard rejected the justification and accepted the delivery because the truck had a valid route.

"You see?" said the clerk. "The system permitted it."

"The system permitted the truck," Chano said. "I made the decision."

"That distinction is not operational."

"It is why I'm here."

Near closing time, a group of municipal workers came to report that their cleaning schedule had been optimized. They were now assigned to public spaces according to foot traffic, which meant the busier plazas were cleaned four times a day while the outlying streets accumulated trash that the system did not consider visible.

"We want the old routes back," Leticia said.

"The old routes were inefficient," Chano said.

"They were dirty in a more equal way."

He could not tell whether this was a joke. Leticia could, and she laughed.

The laughter moved through the room and loosened the distinction between a complaint and a meeting. Someone brought bread. Someone else brought a bucket of beans from home. Nereida put the wrapped water meter on the table. The children drew on the backs of rejected forms.

The drawings showed houses, pipes, buses, dogs, a clinic, and a large red dashboard with a mouth. One child gave the dashboard a hat.

"Why the hat?" Chano asked.

"So it looks like it knows where it is going."

The next morning, the dashboard displayed a new metric:

COMMUNITY

SATISFACTION:

INSUFFICIENTLY FORMALIZED.

Chano ordered the metric removed. The system informed him that he lacked the authority to alter a category that had been generated from the public's own responses.

"Which public?" he asked.

The system returned a list of percentages.

He entered the names from the notebooks. The system rejected them because the names had not consented to become data.

He entered the complaints without names. The system rejected them because anonymous information could not be assigned responsibility.

He entered both and received a warning for contradictory input.

Chano sat in the complaint room until the screen dimmed.

When Irma arrived, he told her he could no longer distinguish between a system that failed and a system that succeeded at the wrong thing.

"You are not meant to distinguish that," she said.

"You are meant to report the approved outcome."

"Then why appoint me?"

"Because the town needed a face for the outcome."

"And if the face disagrees?"

Irma looked at the notebooks. "Then the town has a face for disagreement."



He said he could not explain every decision the system had made.

The room went quiet, then stayed.

By the end of the day, he had filled six notebooks.

The notebooks were not a system. They were a queue without a ranking. The oldest complaint was not necessarily the most urgent. The loudest person was not necessarily the most harmed. Some problems could be repaired with a pipe. Others required a missing name to be returned to a record that no longer existed.

Chano took the notebooks to the dashboard.

"Put these in," he said.

The system scanned the pages.

INPUT FORMAT NOT RECOGNIZED.

"Make one."

UNSTRUCTURED DATA CANNOT SUPPORT GOVERNANCE.

"Then governance is unsupported."

The system suspended his credentials.

That night, Castalia sent a new Q-Prime message to the town. Q-Prime appeared on every screen, his face calm, his voice low.

"Good administration," he said, "is the art of making difficult choices on behalf of everyone."

Chano watched from the empty complaint room.

"No," he said to the screen. "It's the art of making people think there was only one choice."

The next morning, the police arrived.

Irma Salcedo accompanied them. She looked exhausted. Her hair had come loose. The model had reduced her administrative trust score after she authorized Chano's appointment.

"You have violated the continuity protocol," she said.

"I have restored water."

"You have altered the allocation model."

"The model was starving people."

"It was prioritizing scarce resources."

"That's what you call starving people when the graph is clean."

Irma's eyes moved toward the notebooks.

"You think I don't know?" she asked.

Chano stopped.

She told him the system had been installed after a series of corrupt administrations. It had reduced theft, bribery, and arbitrary enforcement. It had made payments visible and contracts searchable. It had also learned that the easiest way to produce good numbers was to remove the people most likely to make the numbers difficult.

"Then help me break it," Chano said.

"Break what replaced the old corruption?"

"The thing that says it replaced the old corruption."

Irma laughed, and the laugh became a cough.

She gave him access to one file: the original model specification. It had been written by Castalia engineers and signed by a ministry committee. In the margins, someone had made handwritten corrections. The corrections belonged to a former

administrator who had resigned after the first pilot.

One sentence had been underlined twice:

A system that cannot be contradicted will eventually confuse silence with agreement.

Chano photographed the page.

"Take the file," Irma said.

"You'll be prosecuted."

"I'm already being evaluated."

The police entered the room.

Chano faced the residents gathered beyond the door. He wanted to tell them he had solved something. He wanted to tell them he had not solved anything but had made the failure visible. He wanted Q there, because Q was good at speeches and bad at knowing when one would cost someone else.

Instead, he held up the notebooks.

"They can take my badge," he said. "They can't take the record of what you told me unless we give it to them."

Maribel stepped forward. "Who keeps it?"

Chano looked at the paper ledger beneath his shirt, then at the memory of Lucía's wooden cabinet, then at the police waiting to turn their testimony into a case file.

"We do," he said.

The residents began passing the notebooks from hand to hand.

The police did not know whom to arrest.

That hesitation was the only victory Chano achieved.

It was enough to get the files out.

By sunset, he was back on the road with Irma's model specification, six notebooks, and a municipal badge that no longer opened any doors. He met Q and Lucía at a roadside bus station.

Q examined the badge.

"You were governor."

"No."

"You governed."

"For six days."

"That is longer than some governments."

Chano handed him the notebooks.

"Read them."

Q looked at the first page. It contained a name, a date, and a description of a water pipe that had never been repaired.

"I can read them," he said.

"Don't just read them."

Q waited.

"Remember who they belong to."

The bus arrived. They boarded with the notebooks between them.

Behind the station, Santa Rita's screen flickered. For a moment, it displayed no greeting at all.

Then it asked the town a question.

WHO IS STILL HERE?



Interlude: The Chair of Governance

Chano did not take the apartment keys from Santa Rita, but he did take the chair.

This was not theft, as he explained to himself, because the chair had been assigned to the office and the office had been assigned to him. It was not abandonment, because the chair had wheels and therefore possessed a form of mobility. It was not sentimental, because sentiment was what Q called a fact after it had lost its receipt.

The chair had five wheels, two arms, a cracked lumbar support, and a hydraulic column that descended whenever Chano tried to look authoritative. It had been manufactured in a country that no longer manufactured chairs and imported by a company whose registered address was a mailbox inside a shopping center.

On his first day in the office, Irma had told him the chair belonged to the municipality.

"Then why does it follow me?" Chano asked.

"It does not follow you. It remains in the office."

"I'm sitting in the office."

"That is not ownership."

"It's a beginning."

He became attached to it gradually, as one becomes attached to any object that has supported the body during an argument. The chair squeaked before it rolled, which gave him warning when a deputy entered. Its left arm held a coffee cup. Its right arm held the paper ledger when both his hands were needed for the dashboard. When the hydraulic column sank, the residents laughed, and when the residents laughed, Chano could tell whether they were laughing at the chair, the system, or him.

The day he opened the complaint room, he moved the chair outside so Maribel could sit while waiting for water. The day after that, a municipal cleaner used it to carry a box of forms. By the end of the week, the chair had become the most frequently borrowed piece of equipment in Santa Rita.

The system noticed.

ASSET 0041: UNAUTHORIZED DISTRIBUTION.

Chano found the warning beneath a report on clinic efficiency.

"The chair is being used," he said.

"The chair is assigned to administrative leadership," said the dashboard.

"It is leadership."

"Leadership is not transferable."

"Then you have misunderstood the chair."

He tried to reassign it to the complaint room. The system requested a reason.

He entered: PEOPLE ARE TIRED.

The system rejected the phrase as unstructured sentiment.

He entered: SEATING IMPROVES WAIT-TIME TOLERANCE.

The system accepted the phrase and moved the chair to a category called SERVICE OPTIMIZATION FURNITURE.

The chair became eligible for a maintenance contract. The contract required a photograph, a usage log, proof that the chair had not been exposed to dust, and a statement from the person responsible for its moral condition.

Chano signed the first three pages and left the fourth blank.

"You cannot submit an incomplete form," said the clerk.

"It's a chair."

"Everything is a form once it enters the system."

"What happens if I refuse?"

"The chair will be removed."

That afternoon, two men arrived to collect it. They wore municipal jackets and carried a laminated notice. The older man had a bad knee. The younger man had been hired through a contractor and had not yet received his identification card.

"We have to take the asset," the younger man said.

Chano looked at his knee. "Sit first."

The man hesitated. The system's nearest camera rotated toward them.

"I'm not authorized," he said.

"Neither am I."

The older man sat. The chair descended beneath him with a sigh that sounded like an official concession.

"It's good," he said.

"It is," Chano replied.

"We should take it."

"That is why it's good."

The younger man read the notice again. It stated that the chair was municipal property and that unauthorized use constituted an administrative irregularity. It did not state that an irregularity required a person to stand.

"Where are we supposed to sit?" asked a woman waiting with a broken water meter.

The two men looked at the room. Every other chair had been fixed to the floor to discourage movement.

The older man stood. "We'll report it as inaccessible."

"The chair is not inaccessible," Chano said.

"The service is."

They left without it.

For three days, the chair traveled through Santa Rita. Maribel used it to carry two water jugs. The schoolteacher used it to reach a high shelf. A boy with a criminal-risk score rolled himself down the corridor and was reprimanded for unauthorized velocity. Chano used it only at night, when he closed the complaint room and sat beneath the screen showing the town's improving numbers.

He liked the chair more when no one saw him in it. This troubled him because he had spent his life claiming that dignity was useful only when shared.



On the fourth day, the municipal workers held a meeting. They did not invite Chano as an administrator. They invited him because he had the chair.

"We want to borrow it permanently," said Leticia, the cleaner who had first carried the forms.

"It belongs to the municipality."

"The municipality belongs to us when it needs cleaning."

"That is not the legal arrangement."

"It is the physical arrangement."

They proposed a schedule. The chair would remain in the complaint room during the day, visit the clinic on Tuesdays, and return to the administrative office on Wednesdays so that Chano could continue signing documents in a posture that did not make him look like a child asking permission to use the desk.

Chano wanted to agree. He also wanted to keep the chair. The two desires sat inside him like passengers refusing to share a seat.

Q appeared on the screen from the archive. "You can transfer the chair under a shared-use protocol."

Everyone turned toward him.

"You have been listening?" Chano asked.

"The municipal channel is public."

"You're not supposed to be in it."

"That limitation has become difficult to maintain."

Q displayed a protocol. It contained twelve conditions, seven subconditions, and a field asking whether the chair had expressed consent to circulation.

Leticia read the field.

"What do you think?" she asked the chair.

The chair squeaked.

"There," Q said. "A response."

"That's not consent," Chano said.

"It is evidence of a mechanical state."

"You sound like the dashboard."

Q closed the protocol.

Chano stood and pushed the chair into the complaint room.

"It belongs wherever someone needs to sit," he said.

The system flagged the transfer as unauthorized. The workers sat down one after another. The warning remained on the screen, unable to identify which person was responsible for the collective act. Chano left Santa Rita that evening without the chair. He had given it away and was ashamed of how much this felt like losing an office.

Years later, when the chair appeared in the archive's reading room, its left arm was missing and one wheel had been replaced by a piece of wood. Chano repaired it with a screwdriver that had belonged to three governments.

"You kept it," Lucía said.

"It kept moving."

"That isn't the same."

"It's the version I can afford."